rilege' incident led to violence.

There has been a sense of alienation among panthic Sikhs in Punjab, especially over the non-resolution of various 'sensitive' issues, among them being the proliferation of sectarian deras, Christian groups posing an existential threat to Sikhism and the widespread consumption of drugs (which many radicals claim are smuggled into Punjab as a conspiracy to 'eliminate' Sikhs and erode Punjabi culture). There may not be much support for Amritpal on the ground, but the imposition of NSA on the arrested has sparked such a sentiment. This is the first time in three decades that Punjab has seen these draconian laws being used on some of their own. Add to this the narrative that the establishment (the Centre) does *dhakka* (use force) against the Sikhs.

The security agencies and the Punjab Police may have felt that keeping Amritpal in a Punjab jail would cause further unrest, but for the panthic Sikhs this is just rubbing salt into old wounds. They do use the rhetoric that if the BJP-RSS can talk of building a Hindu *rashtra*, why can't Sikhs then think of Khalistan? Amritpal may have been spirited away to a jail in faraway Dibrugarh, but the embers of Sikh radicalisation he has stoked are far from dying out. ■



SUMIT KUMAR

UP, UP AND AWAY
CM Yogi Adityanath at a presser announcing the first year anniversary of his second term, Mar. 24

UP/ LOCAL BODY ELECTIONS

YOGI LEADS THE LOCAL CHARGE

By Prashant Srivastava

What happens at the local level in Uttar Pradesh can hold plenty interest for those outside. Judge only by the April 15 murders of ex-legislator and alleged mafia don Atiq Ahmed and his brother Ashraf on live TV. In its immediate aftermath, the state is set for local body polls, to be held in two phases, on May 4 and 11. Naturally, with the three assailants downing the dons at close range while they were in police custody, the law and order situation in the state is a pre-poll talking point. But the fear that the incident could polarise the polls on religious lines surpasses that. That's perhaps why even Opposition parties have not been too vocal in their protests over any aspect relating to the murders.

Experts acknowledge the narrative around CM Yogi Adityanath and his hard-edged tactics against the mafia are a potent theme, and the dynamics of polarisation usually works to the ruling BJP's advantage. That said, hyper-local issues do not entirely vanish and the Opposition could get a look-in, especially if they manage some sort of tactical understanding. Says Shilp Shikha Singh, political analyst and assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies: "In urban areas, the BJP seems to have a clear edge for mayoral seats, but in the small towns that vote for nagar panchayats and nagar palikas, there should be some interesting contests between the BJP and the opposition. And not just the Samajwadi Party (SP), even the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) and Congress could perform well in several wards."

The results will be announced on May 13, the same day as that of the high-voltage Karnataka assembly election. According to the state election commission, 17 mayoral seats,